Religious organizations too found new spaces opening at the end of the twentieth century. Cuba's 1992 Constitution removed language defining the state as atheist, redefining the country instead as a secular state, and banning discrimination against religious believers and practitioners. Along with other Special Period developments, these changes led to a kind of boom in religious practice and presence.

The Pope's 1998 visit to Cuba – the first ever – revealed aspects of both a changing Church and a changing Cuba. The Catholic Church gained more autonomy and power as an institution during the Special Period. It was one of the few entities that had the infrastructure and the international connections to address some of the needs created by the economic crisis. In some ways, the economic crisis led to a crisis of faith too, and some turned to the Church for answers.

In 1992 the government approved the establishment of Caritas Cuba. Caritas, an international Catholic relief organization based in Rome, is active around the world – but had been banned in Cuba until then.[27] In 1993 the U.S.-based Catholic Relief Services initiated a project to support Caritas Cuba, and by 2008 had shipped $27 million in relief supplies.[28]

Afro-Cuban religions experienced a different kind of political opening in the 1990s. Because they are not centrally organized and have no institutional hierarchy or data collection, it's harder to measure increases in religious practice. But Santería, in particular, has boomed as a practice and as a tourist attraction. Katherine Hagedorn's study of the Conjunto Folklórico Nacional de Cuba explains how the government founded the group in 1962 as part of an effort to support and validate Afro-Cuban cultural forms. By the 1990s, practitioners realized that Santería could also be a source of income. Some *santeros* turned commercial and sought to sell the Afro-Cuban religious experience to visitors from abroad.[29] Many Cubans resented what one scholar termed "auto-exoticism" or "*jineterismo cultural*" – prostituting one's culture for dollars.[30]

Cuban film flourished in new ways under the economic constraints that began in the 1990s. As the government's ability to fund the film